Characters and Factions of Aetheln

Document Status

This is the canonical character, faction, and Order summary. It updates the earlier Champions of the First Cycle artifact for the two-faction, mandatory open-world-PvP direction.

Faction and Order names are working names. Character loyalties describe their current position and may change through the story.

Under Issue #104, Crowned Ledger (`faction.crowned_ledger`) and Hundred Witnesses (`faction.hundred_witnesses`) supersede the earlier Dawn Concordat and Unbound Flame as the provisional faction display names. The semantic IDs are stable even when the display names change. Both display names remain provisional working names; final faction naming is owned by Issue #54. Historical research and completed evidence that use the earlier names remain unchanged.

Playable anatomy, visual identity, culture, and presentation contracts are defined in Playable Peoples.

Faction Conflict

Crowned Ledger - Working Name

The Crowned Ledger, previously recorded under the working name Dawn Concordat, believes scarce Ember-light must be regulated and shared under a common law. Its members fear that independent stockpiles will create another Duskbreak.

The Crowned Ledger preserves accountable continuity but risks owned truth: a single lawful record of what happened, held by the few empowered to write it. Its virtues are discipline, collective defense, and continuity. Its dangers are authoritarian control, procedural cruelty, and the belief that individual lives can be sacrificed for stability.

Gameplay identity:

- Wards, banners, formation support, and defensive siege tools.
- Holding ground and protecting shared objectives.
- Regulated travel and resource logistics.
- Doctrine choices that reward coordination and prepared defense.

Hundred Witnesses - Working Name

The Hundred Witnesses, previously recorded under the working name Unbound Flame, believe settlements and individuals who recover Embers should decide how to use them. Its members view the Concord's monopoly as a different form of slow extinction.

The Hundred Witnesses protect plurality but risk fragmentation and paralysis: truth held by many independent witnesses can survive any single tyrant, yet it may never agree on one answer in time to act. Its virtues are autonomy, adaptability, mercy, and local responsibility. Its dangers are fragmentation, hoarding, opportunism, and extremists who confuse freedom with entitlement.

Gameplay identity:

- Mobility, disruption, infiltration, and field improvisation.
- Breaking formations and stealing contested resources.
- Flexible travel and independent supply.
- Doctrine choices that reward timing, adaptation, and coordinated disruption.

The Concord

The Concord is the old legal and religious structure governing Ember use. It is not identical to the Crowned Ledger, although the Crowned Ledger broadly supports it. The Concord attempts to mediate the conflict while also protecting its authority.

The Ashen Choir

The Ashen Choir is hostile to both player factions. It is the surviving remnant of the Lucent Choir and intends to complete the ritual that cracked the Waking Star.

The Ashen Choir must not become a playable faction in the initial design.

The Unison

The Unison is a growing movement that offers relief from unbearable memory. It began as voluntary relief: consenting sufferers asked its practitioners to still a memory, a grief, or a dying moment, and Corvath's preservation practice is widely cited as its most famous precedent. Over the course of the story the Unison evolves from voluntary relief into enforced mercy, deciding for others which suffering must end.

The Unison is not a player faction. Members and sympathizers exist inside both the Crowned Ledger and the Hundred Witnesses, and each faction reads the movement through its own fear: the Crowned Ledger sees unaccountable erasure of the record, and the Hundred Witnesses see a new monopoly over what may be remembered. Its trajectory converges with Sevrin Vale's belief that the Onefold Vault can end suffering outright.

The Five Orders

The Orders are the surviving martial and scholarly institutions that train the Emberbound. In gameplay terms, an Order is the game's class. Under Issue #104, the five Orders below supersede the earlier four initial class concepts (Bulwark, Skeinblade, Embercaller, and Lumen); Oathscar specifically supersedes Skeinblade as the active initial Order working label. Historical research and completed evidence keep the earlier labels unchanged.

Shared Order rules:

- Every listed Order, specialization, and Peak display name is a working name with a stable semantic ID. IDs remain stable when display names change.
- Every playable people and sex may join every Order, and every Order serves either faction. Orders are institutions, not faction organs.
- Each Order swears one oath. Its two specializations are the two dominant interpretations of that oath, and a member's specialization selects which interpretation governs their practice.
- Each Order guards one Peak: a technique that briefly realizes a forbidden version of the character. Peaks are feared, regulated, and central to each Order's taboos.
- Each Order channels one named combat resource. Resource names are working names; each is the selected presentation of the shared OrderResource slot. All resource behavior and numeric tuning remain `TBD`.

Order	Stable ID	Specializations	Peak	Resource	Weapon traditions
Oathscar	`order.oathscar`	Ironwake (`order.oathscar.spec.ironwake`), Last Gate (`order.oathscar.spec.last_gate`)	Oathbreak (`order.oathscar.peak.oathbreak`)	Grudge	Greatsword, sword-and-shield, two-handed spear, dual wield
Nullwright	`order.nullwright`	Ashscript (`order.nullwright.spec.ashscript`), Black Geometry (`order.nullwright.spec.black_geometry`)	Contradiction (`order.nullwright.peak.contradiction`)	Proof	Staff, focus gauntlet, grimoire-blade, orbiting seals
Hushblade	`order.hushblade`	Red Echo (`order.hushblade.spec.red_echo`), Hollow Guard (`order.hushblade.spec.hollow_guard`)	Missing Second (`order.hushblade.peak.missing_second`)	Tempo	Twin knives, sheathed blade, chain-sickle, needle fan
Gravecant	`order.gravecant`	Dirge (`order.gravecant.spec.dirge`), Refrain (`order.gravecant.spec.refrain`)	Last Chorus (`order.gravecant.peak.last_chorus`)	Cadence	Chime-staff, mace-reliquary, chain-censer, tome-rod
Blackfletch	`order.blackfletch`	Far Thorn (`order.blackfletch.spec.far_thorn`), Waykeeper (`order.blackfletch.spec.waykeeper`)	Narrowed Horizon (`order.blackfletch.peak.narrowed_horizon`)	Tension	Longbow, recurve bow, greatbow, tether/trap bow

Every name in the Resource column is the Order-specific presentation of the shared `combat.resource.order` slot: Grudge maps to `order.oathscar`, Proof to `order.nullwright`, Tempo to `order.hushblade`, Cadence to `order.gravecant`, and Tension to `order.blackfletch`. Changing an Order changes which authored resource rules may occupy that slot; it does not turn Health, Endurance, Guard, or Ward into an Order resource. The server validates the selected Order, its stable ID, and the compatible resource definition. A client cannot request another Order's resource identity or claim a gain, spend, or refund.

The prototype remains one `order.oathscar` character using sword and shield. Grudge is canonical Oathscar intent but is not part of the default prototype resource subset. Issue #107 may define one optional Oathbreak exercise; any resulting bounded attribute or ability work remains owned by Issue #19. This document does not schedule the complete Oathscar kit, its specializations, Peak, other weapon traditions, or any other Order. Exact generation, spend, decay, caps, and UI values remain tuning `TBD`.

Oathscar - Working Name

The Oathscar swear to stand where a promise was made. Their oath binds a sworn grievance to the body: an Oathscar carries every unresolved wrong as Grudge and spends it in combat.

- **Recruitment:** the Order accepts petitioners who can name one wrong they refuse to release. Veterans of broken sieges, disgraced guards, and survivors of unpunished crimes are common; the rite of entry is the public statement of the grudge before witnesses.
- **Duties:** hold gates, escorts, and last lines; enforce sworn contracts of protection; stand witness at executions and truces so neither side can later deny what was promised.
- **Taboos:** an Oathscar must not swear a grudge they do not personally hold, abandon a sworn charge while alive, or invoke Oathbreak - the Peak that briefly realizes the self who broke every oath - except when the sworn charge is already lost.
- **Internal conflicts:** the Ironwake interpretation reads the oath as advancing punishment and argues grudges exist to be spent; the Last Gate interpretation reads it as immovable protection and argues a spent grudge is a failed vigil. The Order also disputes whether a lawful order can dissolve a personal grudge.
- **Weapon traditions:** greatsword, sword-and-shield, two-handed spear, and dual wield. Each tradition is taught as a form of standing ground: the greatsword answers many, the shield answers a line, the spear answers a charge, and paired blades answer a single named enemy.
- **Faction relationships:** the Crowned Ledger values Oathscar witness-duty and hires them to guarantee its rulings, but distrusts grudges that outrank the law. The Hundred Witnesses treat a personal grudge as the purest owned truth, but fear the Order's habit of enforcing settlements no community voted for.
- **Named characters:** Kaelen Dross carries the Order's defining wound - his sworn commission against his brother Maren - and his epithet, the Last Gate, names the specialization he embodies. Vothram, the Forgedoor, is an Oathscar of the Ironwake line whose falsified vault records are a live breach of the Order's witness duty.

Canonical Intent

This full design shard has maturity **Canonical Intent**. Display names remain working names, while the semantic IDs below are stable references for the future registry. It defines product behavior and compatibility boundaries; it does not claim **Evidence Validated** or **Implementation Ready** maturity.

The Oathscar's mechanical identity is committed, readable pressure. They take and hold a line with active defense, then answer a witnessed wrong through an aimed, deliberately committed attack. Their base kit must remain functional without a specialization, Grudge, a Skein loadout, equipment bonuses, a Doctrine, or another player. Specialization and build choices change how the Oathscar applies pressure; they do not supply the missing half of an otherwise nonfunctional class.

One authoritative weapon discipline is active in combat. A weapon model, animation, client request, or equipped presentation cannot select or combine discipline rules. The server validates the active discipline, its compatible ability definitions, and any allowed transition before accepting an activation. Rules for learning, changing, and persisting a discipline belong to Issues #112 and #113.

Weapon discipline	Stable ID	Mechanical identity
Greatsword	`order.oathscar.weapon.greatsword`	Broad committed sweeps and heavy Wrought pressure that threaten a held approach but expose readable wind-up and recovery.
Sword-and-shield	`order.oathscar.weapon.sword_and_shield`	Directional defense, short counter-pressure, and deliberate advances that exchange reach and pursuit for control of the immediate line.
Two-handed spear	`order.oathscar.weapon.two_handed_spear`	Aimed reach and charge denial that reward spacing while becoming vulnerable when an opponent crosses the authored point-control window.
Dual wield	`order.oathscar.weapon.dual_wield`	Focused pursuit of one sworn opponent through successive free-aim commitments, without lock-on, homing, or client-selected-target authority.

Ironwake (`order.oathscar.spec.ironwake`) interprets the oath as advancing punishment. It favors forcing a response, spending earned pressure, and continuing through a contested line, but it does not gain automatic contact or protection during commitment. Last Gate (`order.oathscar.spec.last_gate`) interprets the oath as immovable protection. It favors interception, directional defense, and punishments earned by correctly holding a line, but it does not create passive Guard, omnidirectional block, or permanent denial. Neither specialization changes pure free aim, the shared defense order, or the meaning of Health, Endurance, Guard, Ward, or OrderResource.

Grudge (`order.oathscar.resource.grudge`) is the Oathscar presentation of the shared `combat.resource.order` slot. It records server-recognized grievances that the Oathscar can answer through compatible authored actions. A qualifying grant exists only after its source combat result commits;

the server records it at most once under the shared combat grammar's complete committed-result identity, including target, authored result slot, component, and periodic tick identity where applicable. Replay, prediction, reordered delivery, or reconnect cannot grant it twice. A spend is likewise accepted and committed by the server against compatible content and current authoritative state. Grudge is not Guard, bonus Health, Ward, Endurance, threat, or an ownership claim over an opponent. It cannot be granted because a client reports being hit, names a target, or claims a successful block. Qualifying events, decay, bounds, costs, refunds, and every numeric rule remain tuning `TBD`.

Oathbreak (`order.oathscar.peak.oathbreak`) briefly realizes the forbidden Oathscar who abandons the sworn line to force an ending. An accepted activation enters a server-owned temporary Peak state whose compatible Oathscar actions use explicitly authored aggressive variants. If an authored rule spends or grants Grudge, the server validates and commits that resource transition; presentation cannot create or refund it. Oathbreak does not convert Guard into damage, grant invulnerability, bypass Wrought/Cinder/Wake mitigation, erase costs or recovery, or make presentation authoritative. Opponents must receive a distinct activation tell, readable active state, and readable ending/recovery. Their counterplay is to evade the free-aim commitments, break contact, force poor facing, interrupt only where the authored window permits, or punish the defensive actions that Oathbreak replaces. Eligibility, Grudge cost and grant/refund policy during the Peak, duration, action replacements, cancellation, final recovery, and all numeric values remain `TBD`.

The complete base kit must support solo play before specialization or build choices: the Oathscar can approach, apply Wrought damage, defend directionally, dodge, interrupt through an authored action where eligible, recover through the shared combat rules, defeat a representative ordinary enemy, and survive or fail through readable decisions. It must not require an ally to create a target, generate a resource, cover an unavoidable weakness, or finish a basic combat loop. Group play may reward line holding and interception without making solo viability depend on party state.

Oathscar counterplay remains structural:

- attacks and advances carry authored wind-up, active, and recovery phases;
- directional defense loses to valid angle, timing, Guard pressure, or an authored unblockable rule rather than protecting every side passively;
- Endurance, Guard, Grudge, cooldowns, and action state remain distinct limits, with no automatic conversion that hides a failed decision;
- greatsword and spear commitments can be crossed or avoided, dual-wield pursuit can be disengaged or interrupted as authored, and sword-and-shield gives up reach and pursuit for immediate-line control; and
- the Order receives no inherent long-range homing, unavoidable damage, permanent control immunity, free sustain, or client-authoritative shortcut.

The following are representative weave definitions at **Canonical Intent**, not an approved final collection, slot count, unlock schedule, or tuning set:

Kind	Working name and stable ID	Decision changed
Thread	Witnessed Reprisal (`order.oathscar.thread.witnessed_reprisal`)	A committed Parry result (`order.oathscar.ability.parry`) authorizes one compatible follow-up; duplicate result delivery cannot authorize it again.
Keystone	Debt Comes Due (`order.oathscar.keystone.debt_comes_due`)	Makes committed Grudge spends favor continuing offensive pressure while preserving the normal defense and authority rules.
Keystone	The Line Remembers (`order.oathscar.keystone.the_line_remembers`)	Makes correctly resolved directional defense favor deliberate counter-pressure without turning Guard into Grudge or passive damage.

Forms modify only their referenced ability, Threads consume bounded and visible server-owned triggers, and one Keystone changes the build's central rhythm. None may create a target, contact, hit, resource result, or recursive proc from client presentation. On 2026-10-13 the owner re-pointed Witnessed Reprisal from the perfect block to the Parry and superseded five weave definitions tied to the dropped actives; they are listed in Superseded Representative Actives and are redesigned in a later Skein pass. Compatibility, listener budgets, cycles, versioning, and machine-readable generation remain owned by #106; compiled builds, presets, persistence, and atomic equipment changes remain owned by #113.

Sword-and-Shield Prototype Candidate

Only this bounded subset has maturity **Prototype Candidate**. The authoritative discipline is fixed to `order.oathscar.weapon.sword_and_shield` in one controlled combat space. Its default playable contract is exactly:

- Health, Endurance, and active Guard under their shared semantic identities;
- one server-owned, pure-free-aim, three-hit Wrought basic combo (`order.oathscar.ability.sword_shield_basic_chain`);
- directional block, the shared prototype dodge, and exactly three representative actives (owner decision, 2026-10-13, issue #260):
  - Instant Strike (`order.oathscar.ability.instant_strike`), a single aimed weapon strike that hits on press and deals pure Wrought damage, with no Guard pressure, interruption, or knockback, and a relatively low cooldown. It is refused inside the three-hit chain's commitment window, as dodge and block are (owner decision, 2026-10-13, issue #260);
  - Parry (`order.oathscar.ability.parry`), a short timed defensive window. A hit whose authoritative contact time lies inside the window is fully negated, and its attacker is staggered. Only the server decides a parry, from the contact time against the window; a client never claims one; and
  - Stance, two mutually exclusive buffs: Attack Stance (`order.oathscar.ability.attack_stance`) and Defense Stance (`order.oathscar.ability.defense_stance`). Each is cast instantly with no cooldown and lasts about ten minutes (600 s, a provisional owner

value). Casting one replaces the other, so at most one is active. Death removes the active stance, and respawn restores only Health, Endurance, and Guard;
- one representative enemy; and
- authoritative damage, readable acceptance/correction/rejection feedback, death, and respawn.

Instant Strike, Parry, Attack Stance, and Defense Stance are working names; final names stay `TBD`. All damage, Guard pressure, Endurance costs, cooldowns, ranges, shapes, phase timings, the parry window, the stagger duration, the stance magnitudes, recovery, enemy values, and other tuning are `TBD` for their owning implementation and evidence work. The only owner value is the provisional 600 s stance duration, re-tuned at the prototype feel test. The active abilities describe distinct prototype decisions; their working names do not approve animation, VFX, audio, or final balance.

The default prototype does not read, grant, spend, display, or persist Grudge and does not depend on Ironwake, Last Gate, Oathbreak, Forms, Threads, Keystones, equipment, Doctrine, inventory, a specialization trial, weapon learning, or a wider Order roster. It therefore remains functional with no Skein selection and no durable character-system dependency.

One optional Oathbreak exercise may separately instantiate `order.oathscar.peak.oathbreak` with fixed, temporary test state. It is not part of the default loop, does not unlock or persist anything, does not mutate inventory or saved build state, and does not require the default prototype to implement Grudge. The exercise must end by restoring or discarding only its explicit temporary state; disconnect, retry, death, or replay cannot preserve a Peak grant or duplicate a result. Passing that exercise would not validate the full Oathbreak, Grudge, specialization, or Skein designs.

This shard retains existing delivery ownership:

Owner	Boundary retained
#18	Dodge cost, cooldown, authoritative defensive window, correction, and network evidence.
#19	PlayerState-owned GAS attributes, resources, effects, abilities, cooldowns, replication, rollback, and bounded optional-Peak attribute/resource/effect/ability work.
#20	Representative enemy authority, target choice, attack behavior, and runtime evidence.
#21	Integrated death, respawn, reconnect, stale-state cleanup, and duplicate-completion tests.
#60	Server-owned attack timeline, authored free-aim contacts, deterministic ordering, and the three-hit chain.
#61	HUD, readable combat feedback, accessibility-safe cues, and correction/rejection presentation.
#82	Input, camera, bounded aim intent, and measured pure-free-aim feel.
#84	Attack, defense, telegraph, volume, animation, and presentation authoring pipeline.
#106	Registry schema, stable-ID validation, maturity validation, generation, drift checks, and bounded proc/listener rules.
#112	Specialization trial/reset, weapon learning, Heritage, and Order-mastery rules.
#113	Skein compilation, presets, compatibility manifests, persistence, and atomic equipment/build changes.
#115	Downstream canonical, roadmap, brief, ledger, glossary, generated-artifact, and board reconciliation.

No statement in this shard is runtime, packaged, balance, performance, security, readability, accessibility, or QA evidence. Only the bounded subset above is a Prototype Candidate; every broader Oathscar definition remains Canonical Intent.

Superseded Representative Actives

On 2026-10-13 the owner replaced the earlier three representative actives (issue #260). They are dropped as designed, including Gate Step's movement, and their stable IDs are not reused:

- Gate Step (`order.oathscar.ability.gate_step`), an aimed shield-led advance with Wrought contact and Guard pressure, superseded by Instant Strike;
- Sworn Rebuke (`order.oathscar.ability.sworn_rebuke`), an aimed committed Wrought answer with an interruption rule, superseded by Instant Strike; and
- Hold the Line (`order.oathscar.ability.hold_the_line`), a held directional defense with a Guard result, superseded by Parry.

The weave definitions tied to them are superseded and are redesigned later in a Skein pass (issue #260). Their former intent, kept for that pass:

- Form Advancing Answer (`order.oathscar.form.gate_step.advancing_answer`): changed Gate Step into a more committed advance with authored contact, movement, and recovery.
- Form Rooted Answer (`order.oathscar.form.gate_step.rooted_answer`): gave up Gate Step's advance to contest Guard from a held position; mutually exclusive with Advancing Answer.
- Form Closed Oath (`order.oathscar.form.hold_the_line.closed_oath`): narrowed Hold the Line to a more committed directional defense with a readable facing requirement.
- Thread Unbroken Sequence (`order.oathscar.thread.unbroken_sequence`): completing the basic chain without a miss changed the next compatible Sworn Rebuke.
- Thread Ground Reclaimed (`order.oathscar.thread.ground_reclaimed`): a committed dodge result changed the next compatible Gate Step; a predicted dodge alone could not trigger it.

These five IDs are set aside: they are not registry records, because the registry has no superseded state without a same-kind replacement. Whether the Skein pass reuses them or issues new IDs is open (lane default: new IDs). Witnessed Reprisal stays and now answers the Parry.

Nullwright - Working Name

The Nullwright swear to test what the world claims is true. They treat the Deepwake's rejected histories as propositions and combat as demonstration; their resource, Proof, accumulates as their claims survive contact.

- **Recruitment:** the Order recruits from archivists, failed Concord clerks, and anyone who has caught the world in a contradiction. Entry requires publicly disproving one accepted account, however small.

- **Duties:** audit Ember records and attunement claims, map unstable Deepwake incursions, and unmake constructs of forced history left over from the Great Concordance.
- **Taboos:** a Nullwright must not assert what they cannot demonstrate, falsify a record even to save a life, or hold the Peak of Contradiction - briefly realizing a self whose premises are false - long enough to believe it.
- **Internal conflicts:** Ashscript practitioners erase failed histories and argue the kindest record is a closed one; Black Geometry practitioners bind contradictions into standing seals and argue nothing should be erased before it is understood. Their standing dispute is whether the Waking Star's intent is a solvable question.
- **Weapon traditions:** staff, focus gauntlet, grimoire-blade, and orbiting seals. The Order teaches each as a notation: the staff states, the gauntlet underlines, the grimoire-blade cites, and the seals hold open arguments in the air.
- **Faction relationships:** the Crowned Ledger relies on Nullwright audits to keep its single record honest and resents how often the audits succeed. The Hundred Witnesses admire the Order's refusal to accept owned truth while suspecting that Proof is simply a ledger by another name.
- **Named characters:** Aldrec Fane, the Pyrelaw, works in the Nullwright manner - his case against Serra is real evidence serving an inhuman conclusion, the exact failure the taboos exist to prevent. Saeril, Nine-Lights, is the Order's living cautionary text: her journal is a Nullwright record of a self she can no longer demonstrate. Her guiding encounters raise questions the Order must investigate; spirit testimony does not demonstrate the Star's intention or settle an accusation.

Hushblade - Working Name

The Hushblade swear to end violence in the least time possible. Their art is subtraction - the removed step, the unspent breath, the missing second - and their resource, Tempo, is the rhythm they steal from a fight.

- **Recruitment:** the Order takes students who survived violence they could not match, and teaches that reads, timing, and judgment beat raw attunement. Many recruits arrive through Nhalen's public salles.
- **Duties:** escort negotiators through mixed territory, remove specific military targets under faction sanction, and train civilians to survive the frontier.
- **Taboos:** a Hushblade must not prolong a kill, take a contract on a target they cannot name, or enter the Missing Second - the Peak that briefly realizes the self who was never seen - to escape a debt rather than a death.
- **Internal conflicts:** the Red Echo interpretation pursues and punishes, arguing that a fight ends when the aggressor cannot repeat it; the Hollow Guard interpretation slips and protects, arguing that a fight ends when the victim is out of reach. The Order also argues over sanctioned kill contracts: discipline or hire-murder with etiquette.

- **Weapon traditions:** twin knives, sheathed blade, chain-sickle, and needle fan. Each is taught as a grammar of economy: the knives converse, the sheathed blade answers once, the chain-sickle controls the distance of the conversation, and the needle fan punctuates it.
- **Faction relationships:** the Crowned Ledger licenses Hushblade contracts to keep killing accountable and on record; the Order accepts the license and ignores it when the record would name a client. The Hundred Witnesses shelter Hushblades as proof that skill owes nothing to sanctioned attunement, while quietly fearing blades that answer to no assembly.
- **Named characters:** Nhalen, the Gutterlight, is the Order's finest living instructor and its conscience - severed from Ember attunement, he embodies the claim that the art needs no borrowed Ember power. His spirit identity supplies no replacement combat advantage. Serra Vale trains in the Hushblade manner under scrutiny from both factions; Kaelen trained her early guard and knows what the Concord's demands are doing to her.

Gravecant - Working Name

The Gravecant swear that nothing true should end unwitnessed. They sing the dying into coherent memory and the living back into continuity; their resource, Cadence, is the measured breath of that song.

- **Recruitment:** the Order calls singers, Ninh-priests, bonesetters, and mourners - anyone who has kept a vigil to its end. Entry is a night spent witnessing a stranger's passing and recording it truly.
- **Duties:** keep the witnessed records from which the Emberbound respawn, tend Forgettings when they can be recovered and end them when they cannot, and hold funeral truces that both factions honor. Local spirit testimony must be assessed alongside other evidence; it cannot replace a coherent witnessed record or establish that every dead person survives as a spirit.
- **Taboos:** a Gravecant must not falsify a witnessed record, sing the Last Chorus - the Peak that briefly realizes the self who already died - over one who can still be saved, or refuse witness to an enemy.
- **Internal conflicts:** the Dirge interpretation carries endings to the unwilling and shades toward the Unison's enforced mercy; the Refrain interpretation restores and repeats, holding that a witness serves the living first. The Unison's evolution is the Order's central crisis: relief that was once asked for is beginning to be imposed.
- **Weapon traditions:** chime-staff, mace-reliquary, chain-censer, and tome-rod. Each doubles as liturgical instrument: the chime-staff keeps the measure, the reliquary carries a witnessed name, the censer marks the boundary of a vigil, and the tome-rod is the record made weapon.
- **Faction relationships:** the Crowned Ledger treats Gravecant records as admissible law and presses to own them; the Order refuses, holding that a witness belongs to the witnessed. The Hundred Witnesses celebrate the Order as a hundred witnesses in literal fact, yet resist any suggestion that its records outrank a community's memory.
- **Named characters:** Matron Halveth, the Ledger, commands the Order's lawful wing and authorized Kaelen's commission; her name is the Crowned Ledger's argument made flesh. Corvath, the Still, stands at the Order's edge: his glass preservation is either the perfect witness

or the refusal to let a record close, and the Unison claims him as precedent either way.

Blackfletch - Working Name

The Blackfletch swear to see the path before it is walked. They are wardens of distance - scouts, hunters, and route-keepers - and their resource, Tension, is the drawn stillness between sighting and release.

- **Recruitment:** the Order recruits frontier guides, caravan scouts, and Selaen-trained route observers and spirit interpreters. Entry is a solitary crossing of hostile ground with nothing but a bow and one arrow, returned unspent.
- **Duties:** watch the frontier thresholds where protected territory ends, mark and tether Deepwake incursions before they spread, keep caravan routes and Emberfall predictions honest, and deny ground rather than take it.
- **Taboos:** a Blackfletch must not loose without a named target, abandon a marked route while travelers still trust it, or hold the Narrowed Horizon - the Peak that briefly realizes the self who sees only one future - after the shot is taken. "Named target" is an Order oath and authored intent, not a target lock, client-selected authoritative target, guaranteed contact, or exception to pure free aim.
- **Internal conflicts:** the Far Thorn interpretation strikes at the greatest distance and argues the kindest arrow arrives before the war does; the Waykeeper interpretation traps, tethers, and escorts, arguing that an Order of wardens must never become an Order of assassins. The Order also disputes how far to trust a local spirit's guidance before checking walked ground. Listening is learned practice open to every people, and no testimony makes a route safe merely because a Vesh carries it.
- **Weapon traditions:** longbow, recurve bow, greatbow, and tether/trap bow. The traditions are taught as ranges of responsibility: the longbow watches a region, the recurve rides with a caravan, the greatbow answers a siege, and the tether/trap bow closes a route without a corpse.
- **Faction relationships:** the Crowned Ledger contracts Blackfletch wardens to police regulated routes and resents that the Order also marks the Ledger's own convoys. The Hundred Witnesses depend on Blackfletch paths for independent supply and chafe when a Waykeeper closes a route no assembly agreed to close.
- **Named characters:** the Order keeps Selaen's current observations and route records and is the standing customer of Lanternrest's interpreters, which puts it inside the Vesh argument over guidance, judgment, and responsibility. Nhalen sends Hushblade students to Blackfletch wardens to learn patience, and Aldrec Fane uses chartered Blackfletch trackers in his hunt for Ashen Choir survivors - a charter the Waykeeper line publicly protests.

The Emberbound Table

The Emberbound Table contains champions whose loyalties divide the world. They are connected by the Duskbreak, Concord law, and Choirmaster Sevrin Vale.

The Emberbound are those who carry realized Embers. When an Emberbound dies, the world restores them from their last coherent witnessed record; keeping those records true is a Gravecant duty. What an Emberbound loses between the record and the death is a story question, not a combat statistic.

Kaelen Dross - The Last Gate

- **People:** Aurin
- **Order:** Oathscar, Last Gate specialization
- **Current alignment:** Crowned Ledger
- **Combat lesson:** block, flank, feint, and punish

Kaelen served as the Concord's executioner. His final commission was his own brother, Maren, who murdered pilgrims for a dying Ember. Kaelen performed the death rite himself and forged his tower shield from the door of their family home.

Kaelen believes law prevented greater bloodshed, but Corvath's preservation of Maren forces him to live beside the possibility that duty did not end his brother's suffering.

Conflict:

- Enforces the system Nhalen considers unjust.
- Respects Vothram despite their opposing politics.
- Trained Serra and recognizes that the Concord is consuming her family.
- Could become either the Crowned Ledger's unbreakable defender or the person who finally refuses an order.

Serra Vale - The Ashen Heir

- **People:** Aurin
- **Order:** Hushblade
- **Current alignment:** undecided at the beginning
- **Combat lesson:** attack commitment, dodge timing, and recovery punishment

Serra is the last known descendant of Sevrin Vale, the Choirmaster who cracked the Star. Rather than execute the Vale family, the Concord condemned every generation to publicly earn back a name that can never be cleared.

The Ashen Choir has begun contacting her. Her story is not a simple corruption arc: both factions want to turn her inherited guilt into a political weapon.

Conflict:

- Crowned Ledger leaders demand proof of loyalty that can never be complete.
- Hundred Witnesses leaders offer freedom but may want her name more than her trust.

- Aldrec believes she is already compromised.
- Her faction decision is a major story pivot and remains intentionally open.

Nhalen - The Gutterlight

- **People:** Vesh
- **Order:** Hushblade
- **Current alignment:** Hundred Witnesses
- **Combat lesson:** reads, timing, and skill over raw attunement

Nhalen killed an Ashen Choir agent to save a captive child. No sanctioned arbiter was present, so the Concord applied its law without considering motive. His attunement was severed and he was permanently barred from holding an Ember.

The punishment cut off his Ember attunement without erasing his embodied spirit identity or connection to the world's spirits. He understands following the Light as attending to a life in danger, and saving the child expressed that practice. His conviction does not prove the facts: Aldrec's suppressed evidence establishes that the killing was justified, not a spirit's verdict.

Nhalen fights without supernatural advantage and remains one of the finest combat instructors alive. Spirit listening gives him no substitute combat power, certain foresight, or knowledge of hidden enemies.

Conflict:

- Aldrec confirmed the killing was justified and concealed that truth.
- Kaelen represents the enforcement that destroyed Nhalen's future.
- Nhalen opposes the Concord but rejects indiscriminate revenge.
- He teaches players that equipment and light create options, not automatic victory.
- Saeril's uncertainty tests whether he can support a witness without accepting an accusation on faith; he asks her to investigate rather than name an enemy because a light appeared to guide her.

Saeril - Nine-Lights

- **People:** Vesh
- **Order:** Nullwright
- **Current alignment:** public Crowned Ledger figurehead
- **Combat lesson:** gap closing, interruption, and zone pressure

Saeril is the greatest living Ember champion. Each Ember she integrated consumed a memory. She records her lost identity in a journal because she no longer remembers why she began climbing.

Her title remembers nine personal guiding encounters with the world's spirits. They are part of her own practice of following the Light, not a racial gift of prophecy. Other witnesses' fragments cannot substitute for the identity her lost memories once formed.

The ninth light brought fragmentary testimony that she interprets as a warning of possible betrayal within the Emberbound Table. It guarantees neither a future event nor the identity or guilt of a traitor. She has not revealed the warning and must decide what to investigate, whom to trust, and when speaking would protect others rather than condemn someone without evidence.

Conflict:

- The Crowned Ledger uses her as proof that controlled ascension works.
- The Hundred Witnesses see her as proof that the system consumes its champions.
- Matron Halveth manages her decline.
- Her eventual decision can change the perceived legitimacy of the faction war.
- Nhalen challenges her to separate guidance from proof; accepting his counsel may expose how much certainty the Crowned Ledger has built around her image.

Aldrec Fane - The Pyrelaw

- **People:** Aurin
- **Order:** Nullwright, Ashscript specialization
- **Current alignment:** Crowned Ledger hardliner
- **Combat lesson:** movement, pressure zones, and low-health danger

Aldrec is a Concord inquisitor whose family died in an Ashen Choir atrocity. His commitment to destroying the Choir is sincere.

He also verified that Nhalen acted to save a child and allowed the punishment to stand because he believed the law's example mattered more than one innocent life.

Conflict:

- Builds a case against Serra from evidence that is real but incomplete.
- Audits Vothram's vault while Vothram falsifies its records.
- Treats Hundred Witnesses autonomy as the first stage of another catastrophe.
- Embodies the danger of correct facts serving an inhuman conclusion.

Corvath - The Still

- **People:** Kell
- **Order:** Gravecant, Refrain specialization
- **Current alignment:** Hundred Witnesses sympathizer
- **Combat lesson:** line of sight, healing angles, and area control

Corvath crystallized from the glassed earth during the Duskbreak and remembers the catastrophe from inside its light. He carries the Kell face, horns, external ears, and clawed extremities, but the catastrophe realized his entire body as living glass. Ordinary Kell have renewing ivory-quartz plates over dark amethyst connections; Corvath's whole material state is exceptional and is not an available player appearance.

He preserves people at the instant before death as conscious, painless living glass. Among them is Maren Dross. Corvath considers this mercy; others consider it an endless refusal to let the dead pass.

For Kell who understand continuity through growth and repair, Corvath presents an intimate contradiction: he preserves a life by preventing its next change. His subjects' consciousness and suspended deaths are not an ordinary property of Kell crystal bodies, nor a technique available merely by being Kell. His practice makes the dispute over consent, remembrance, and release personal before it becomes the Unison's political promise.

Conflict:

- Rejects Concord ownership of memory and death.
- Opens the sealed Hollow Choirhouse for the player.
- Opposes Halveth over whether remembrance belongs in a ledger or a living witness.
- His preservation practice divides even his Hundred Witnesses allies, and the Unison claims it as precedent.

Vothram - The Forgedoor

- **People:** Kell
- **Order:** Oathscar, Ironwake specialization
- **Current alignment:** covert Hundred Witnesses supporter
- **Combat lesson:** Guard and Endurance pressure, and heavy commitment

Vothram forged the instruments Sevrin used to crack the Star. He did not know their purpose, but ignorance did not save the cities they destroyed.

His precision craft comes from study of layered materials, joints, and resonance. Kell artisans see a joined fracture as evidence that something was kept alive through change; the Concordance instead promised to make history permanent. Vothram helped build its instruments without understanding what that promise would demand. The ritual's power came from its use of the Star, not from his race or the crystal within his body.

He now guards the Concord's Ember vault. Secretly, he preserves memory-Embers that the law requires him to surrender and allow to expire.

He tends the archive as carefully as a living surface, repairing its vessels and maintaining its records. Yet secrecy denies the people whose histories he holds a voice in that care. His guilt has made preservation a duty he cannot put down, even when it begins to resemble ownership. His archive uses

learned memory craft; it is not a store of memories inside his anatomy.

Conflict:

- His archive can preserve history or become a private hoard.
- The Ashen Choir knows the vault's true inventory.
- Aldrec is closing in on the falsified records.
- Kaelen is his rival, friend, and political opposite.

Matron Halveth - The Ledger

- **People:** Aurin
- **Order:** Gravecant, Dirge specialization
- **Current alignment:** Crowned Ledger authority
- **Combat lesson:** patience, denial, and cooldown discipline

Halveth controls attunement rites. She once refused an unready village champion. Without an eligible claimant, the village could not replace its dying Ember-well, and hundreds died.

She records every person affected by her decisions but continues to believe that consistent law is the only barrier against collapse.

Conflict:

- Represents lawful harm rather than personal malice.
- Controls access to power the Hundred Witnesses want decentralized.
- Manages Saeril's loss of memory.
- Authorized Kaelen's commission against Maren.

Primary Antagonist

Choirmaster Sevrin Vale

- **Faction:** Ashen Choir
- **Role:** initial dungeon antagonist and living origin of the faction crisis

Sevrin led the Great Concordance, the attempt to make the golden age eternal by forcing incompatible histories to coexist. The ritual cracked the Waking Star, caused the Duskbreak, and left him sustained by the stolen light.

He believes the failure came from incomplete execution rather than a false premise. He now believes the Onefold Vault - a completed Concordance holding every history reconciled in one place - can end suffering itself. The Waking Star never clearly commands him: whether his conviction is guidance,

echo, or delusion remains disputed, and that dispute is deliberate canon. Both player factions oppose him, but each uses his crime to justify a different future for Ember control. The Unison's turn toward enforced mercy runs parallel to his promise.

Relationship Threads

Law and Autonomy

Halveth authorizes, Kaelen enforces, Aldrec investigates, and Nhalen bears the punishment. Their conflict gives the faction war a human cost.

Blood of the Duskbreak

Sevrin designed the ritual, Vothram forged its instruments, Corvath was created by its destruction, Serra inherited its blame, and Aldrec hunts its survivors.

Memory and Ownership

Saeril loses memories to power, Vothram steals memories to preserve them, Corvath keeps memory alive in glass, and Halveth records the dead in law. The faction conflict asks whether memory can ever be owned for the common good.

Kell renewal sharpens this conflict: a person may remain themselves through visible change, while an archive can retain a past its subject no longer wants to carry. Vothram maintains the record, Corvath arrests the moment, and living Kell communities must decide when care requires preservation and when it requires release.

Vesh spirit listening adds another witness without ending the argument. A local spirit's account may conflict with a survivor's recollection or a kept record; care requires hearing it without treating it as ownership of the truth. Nhalen and Saeril must choose how to act when compassion calls them toward someone whose account they cannot yet verify.

Future Fractures

- Saeril's ninth light raises a possible betrayal that remains unproven.
- Serra must choose whether either faction deserves her loyalty.
- Kaelen may refuse an order involving Maren.
- Aldrec's concealment of Nhalen's innocence can damage the Crowned Ledger.
- Vothram's archive can strengthen the Hundred Witnesses' cause or expose its hypocrisy.

Character Creation Rules

- Aurin, Kell, Vesh, and future playable races support male and female characters.
- Sex, body preset, and race do not change combat statistics or hitboxes.
- Every playable race may use every supported Order (the game's class).
- Every playable race may join either player faction.
- Character appearance and voice are independent from Order, faction, Skein, equipment, and progression data.
- Aurin, Kell, and Vesh use the race-specific appearance and shared combat contracts defined in Playable Peoples.

Faction selection enters the playable delivery in 2.0. Before that stage, persisted characters use `Faction = Unassigned` and have no Doctrine. The approved one-time selection then assigns the protected starting territory, faction story, and Doctrine; any later faction-change policy remains open.